

2026 FIFA World Cup Final

Prediction-Performance Dossier · Spain vs Argentina · MetLife Stadium · 19 July 2026

FULL TIME: Spain 1-0 Argentina (AET)

Ferran Torres 106 (2nd period of extra time) — Spain's second men's World Cup title (also 2010, also won 1-0 in extra time). Denies Argentina back-to-back titles -- would have been the first repeat champion since Brazil 1958/1962.

Checkpoint	Match state	Spain	Argentina	Winner call	Result
Pre-match	0-0 (not started)	57.8%	42.2%	Spain	Correct
Halftime	0-0	54.7%	45.3%	Spain	Correct
Minute 82	0-0	52.7%	47.3%	Spain	Correct

This is a single realized match (n=1). Brier scores below show this forecast beat the coin-flip baseline (0.25) on the outcome that actually happened -- they are evidence of a reasonable call, not a validated calibration claim. Calibration requires many repeated trials across many matches.

Method

Market de-vigging (proportional + power method) on two independent odds sets (FanDuel/DraftKings/Oddschecker consensus and the Kalshi prediction-market contract) blended with World Football Elo and the Opta supercomputer's 25,000-simulation preview (weights 55/30/15). The blend calibrates a Dixon-Coles-adjusted Poisson score engine, run through a 500,000-trial Monte Carlo covering 90 minutes, extra time at reduced intensity, and a penalty shootout. Two live updates re-ran the same engine conditioned on the actual match state: at halftime (0-0) and at minute 82 (still 0-0), the latter solved in closed form with an explicit sensitivity sweep on Argentina's shootout win probability — the single most decision-relevant assumption once the match reached that stage.

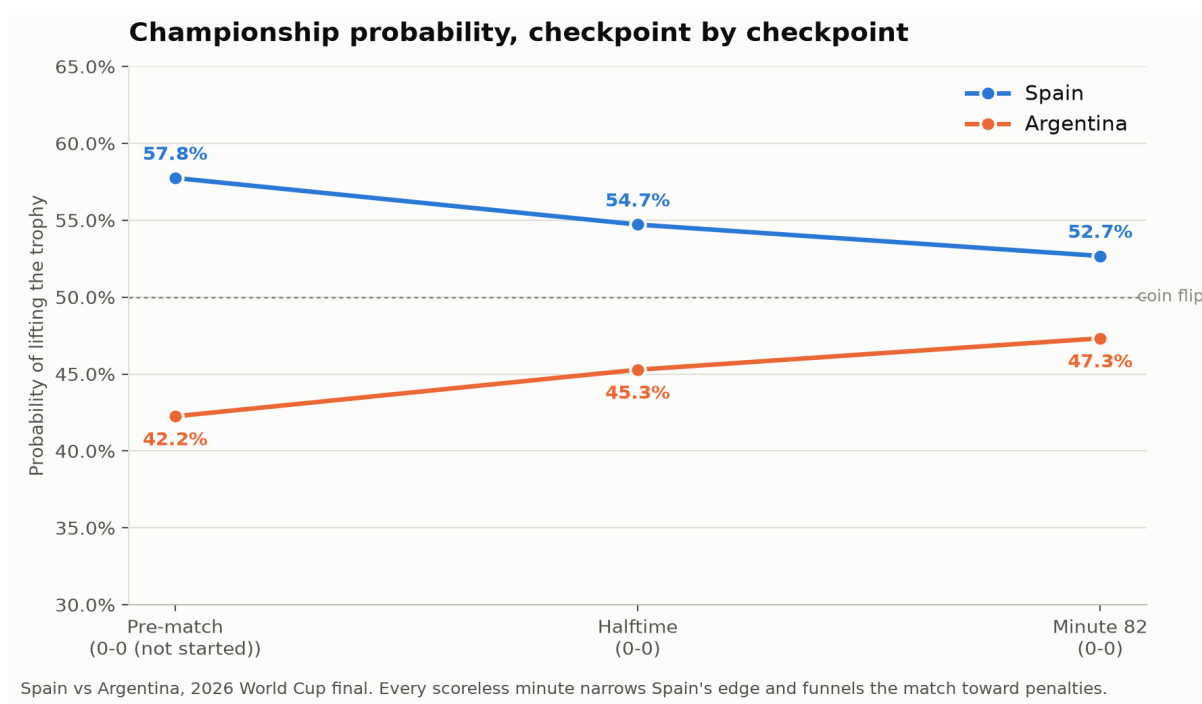


Figure 1. Championship probability at each forecast checkpoint.

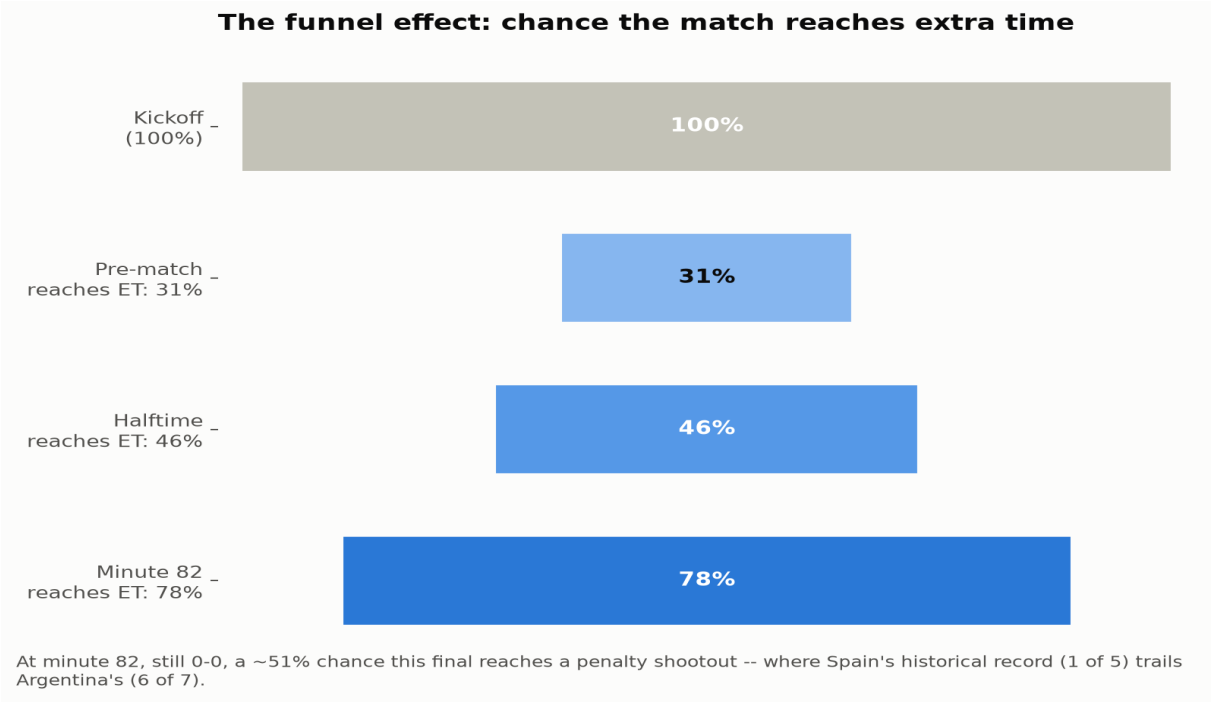


Figure 2. Chance the match reaches extra time, checkpoint by checkpoint.

Path to the trophy & scoreline grid

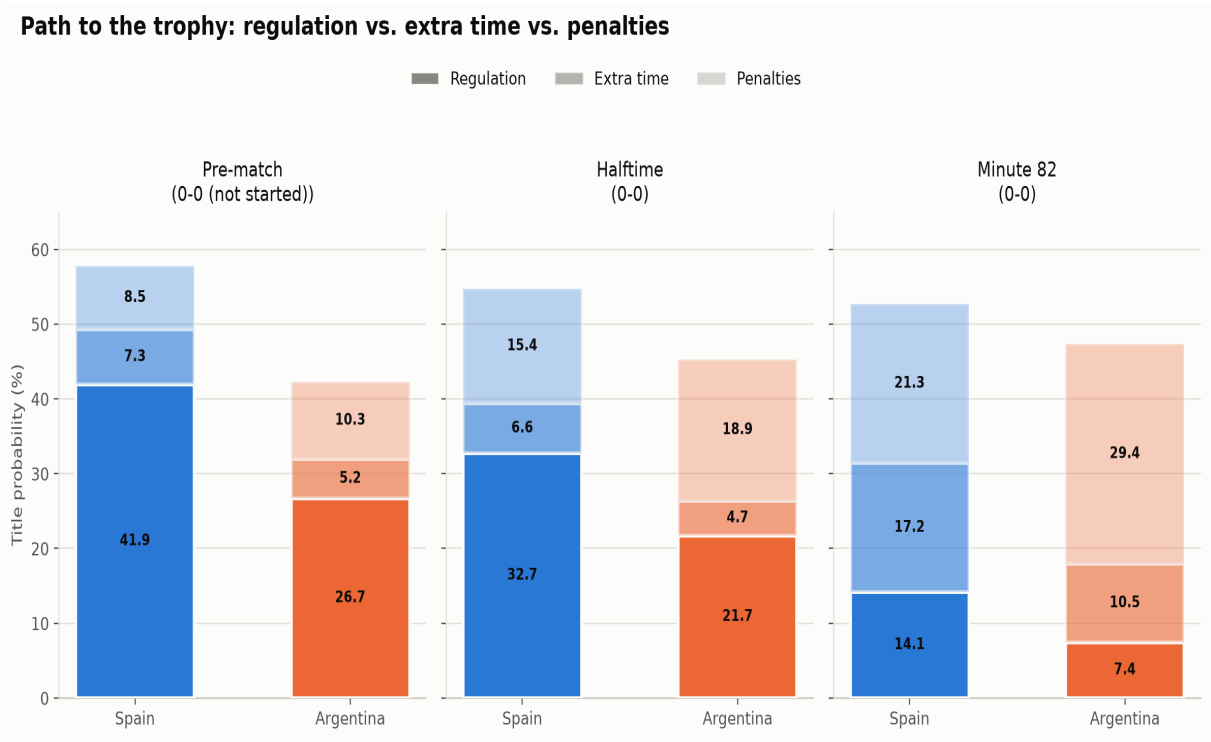


Figure 3. Title probability split by stage (regulation / extra time / penalties).

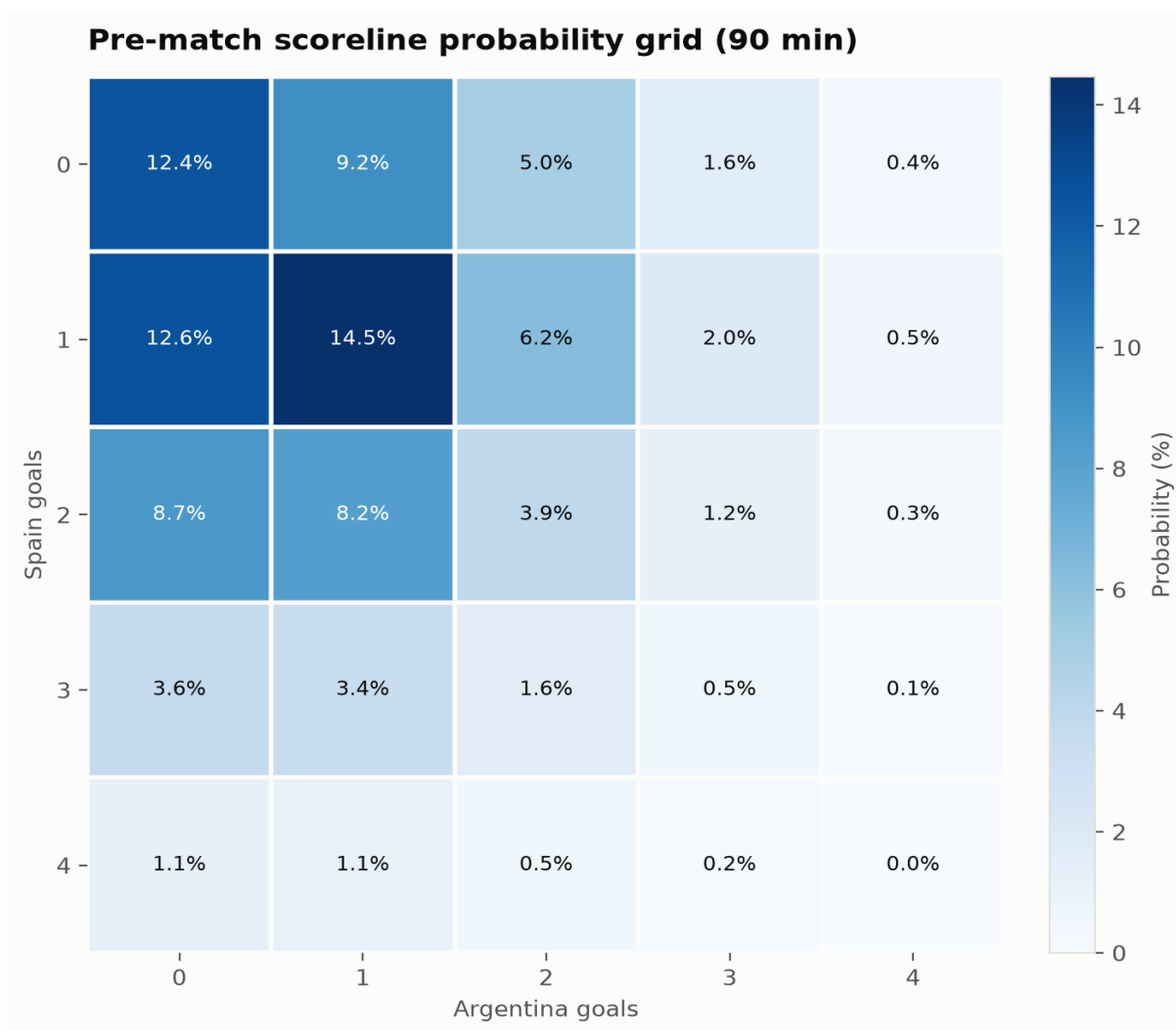


Figure 4. Pre-match scoreline probability grid (Dixon-Coles Poisson, 90 minutes).

Where the estimate was fragile

At minute 82 the entire verdict hinged on one number: Argentina's assumed penalty-shootout win probability. The sweep below shows exactly where the favorite flips (~63%). The central estimate (58%) kept Spain a narrow favorite; the match never tested this branch — it was decided by an extra-time goal before a shootout was needed.

Where the estimate is fragile: two sensitivity sweeps

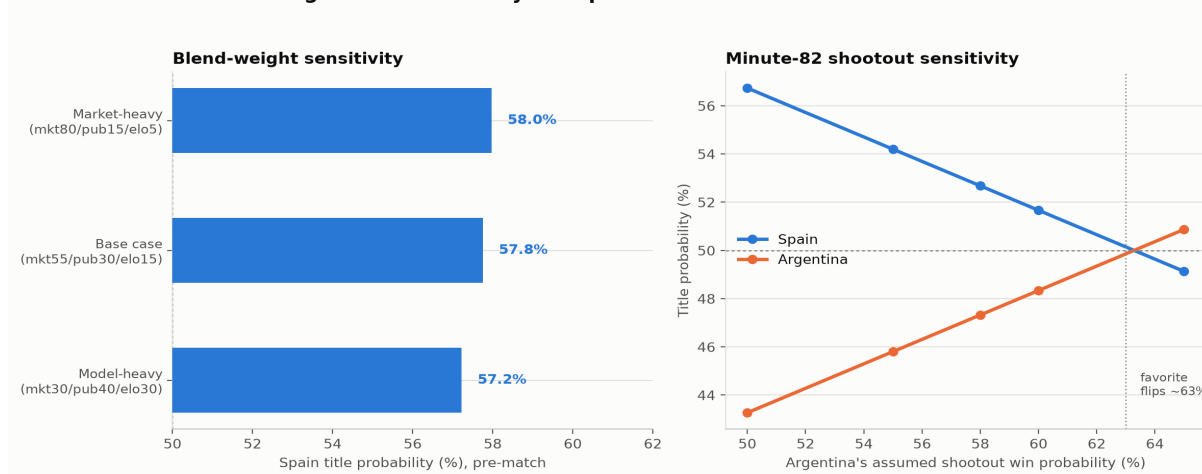


Figure 5. Blend-weight sensitivity (left) and minute-82 shootout sensitivity (right).

36-month form trend

World Football Elo rating for both finalists, reconstructed from primary match-by-match data (eloratings.net). Both teams won their respective continental titles on the same day, 14 July 2024 — Spain (Euro 2024) and Argentina (Copa America 2024) — before converging on this final.

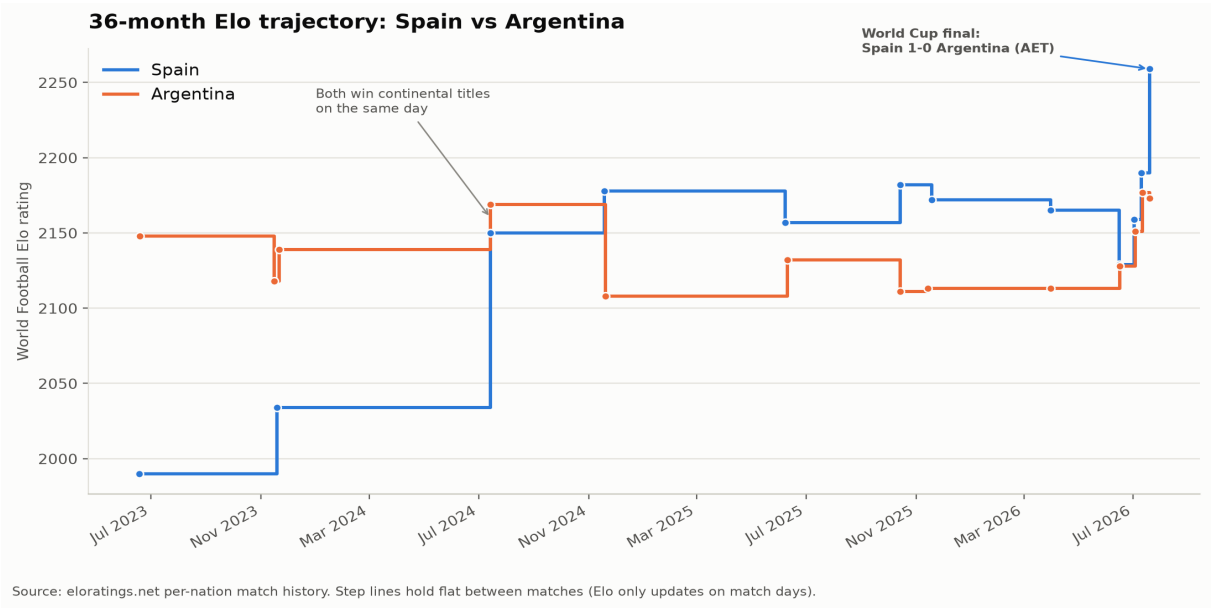
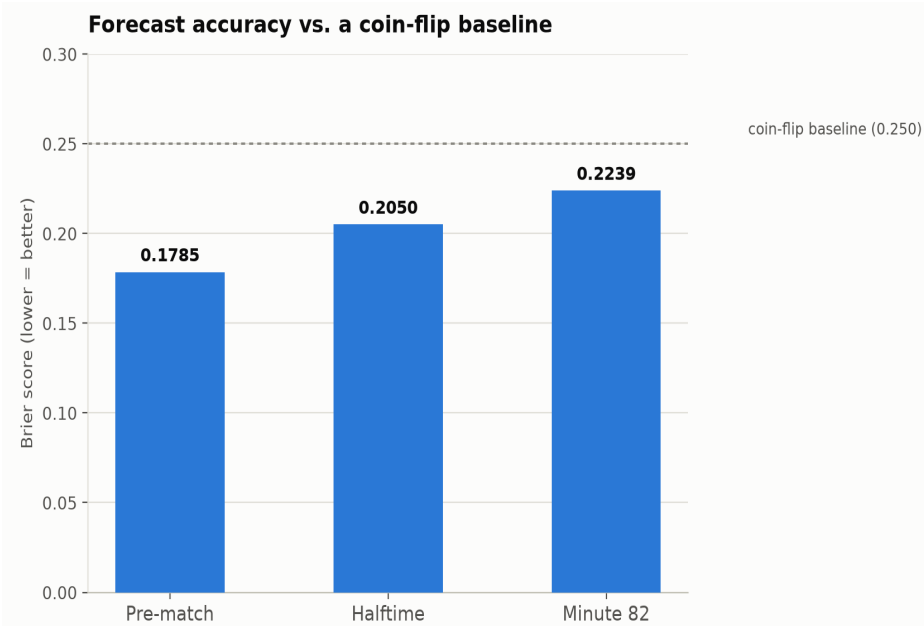


Figure 6. Elo trajectory, July 2023 to the final whistle.

Prediction-performance audit



Final result: Spain 1-0 Argentina (AET). All three checkpoints correctly favored Spain and beat the naive baseline. n=1 match -- this is not a validated calibration claim.

Figure 7. Brier score per checkpoint vs. the coin-flip baseline.

Right, wrong, and untested

Verdict	Note
Right	Favored Spain at all three checkpoints; Spain won.
Right	Assigned 78.4% to extra time at minute 82; the match went to extra time.
Right	0-0 was the model's highest-weight 90-minute scoreline by minute 82 — exactly the 90-minute result.
Partially right	1-0 was the model's #2 most likely 90-minute scoreline pre-match (12.5%) and is the exact final score, but it arrived
Untested, not wrong	The shootout sensitivity sweep was the most decision-relevant analysis at minute 82; the match never reached pen
Blind spot	Enzo Fernandez's red card came in stoppage time of regulation, after the minute-82 checkpoint. The model had no
Next time	Add a live-event layer (cards, dismissals, injuries) and run live updates every 10-15 minutes rather than at two fixed

For entertainment and forecasting practice only — not betting advice. Full methodology, verified sources, and reproducible code: [final-forecast/README.md](#) in the 2026-Data-World-Champ repository.